

Harbour Light

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The lamp had not been lit in forty years, which did not stop people from seeing it.

Trawlermen reported it in the log as a courtesy, the way you might mention a smell. Two flashes, a pause, one flash. Never in fog, which was the part nobody could make sit right. Ghosts are supposed to prefer fog.

The harbourmaster kept a file. It was not an official file. It lived in the drawer with the fuses and the spare padlocks, and it contained forty years of small handwriting and no conclusions.

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In the spring a woman came from the university with equipment in a hard case and a theory about phosphorescence. She spent eleven nights on the east wall with a camera pointed at nothing and came back on the twelfth with the case unopened.

“Did you see it?” the harbourmaster asked.

“I saw it.”

“And?”

She thought about it for a while. Out past the wall the water did what it does, which is refuse to hold still long enough to be measured.

“It’s not a light,” she said. “It’s a habit.”

He waited, because he had been a harbourmaster for a long time and knew that people finish sentences if you leave them alone with them.

“Somebody stood up there every night for thirty-one years and did the same nine seconds,” she said. “You do a thing for thirty-one years, the doing of it gets into the stone. That’s all. It’s not him. It’s just the shape he left.”

The harbourmaster wrote it down that night in the small handwriting, and filed it with the fuses, and did not put a conclusion at the bottom.

Two flashes. A pause. One flash.

